

Lesson 1 A puma at large



Listen then answer the question below.

Where must the puma have come from?

Pumas are large, cat-like animals found in the Americas. When reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been **spotted** 45 miles south of London, they were not taken seriously. However, as the **evidence** began to **accumulate**, experts from the zoo felt **obligated** to investigate, because the descriptions given by people who claimed to have seen the puma were extremely similar.

- The **hunt** for the puma began in a small village where a woman picking **blackberries** saw 'a large cat' only five yards away. It immediately ran away when she saw it, and experts confirmed that a puma will not attack a **person** unless it is **cornered**. The search proved difficult, because the puma was often seen in one place in the morning and in another twenty miles away in the evening. Wherever it went, it left a trail behind of dead deer and small animals like rabbits. Paw prints were seen in several places and puma fur was found clinging to bushes. Several people reported hearing 'cat-like noises' at night and a businessman on a fishing trip saw the puma in a tree. The experts were now fully convinced that the animal was a puma, but where had it come from? Since no pumas had been reported missing from any zoo in the country, this one must have been owned by a private collector and somehow managed to escape. The hunt went on for several weeks, but the puma was not caught. It is disturbing to think that a dangerous wild animal is still at large in the quiet countryside.



New words and expressions

puma (title) /'pu:mə/ *n.* Large, wild American cat

spot /spɑ:t/ *v.* Notice or see

evidence /'evidəns/ *n.* Proof or signs of truth

accumulate /ə'kju:mjə,leɪt/ *v.* To gather and grow

obligate /'ɑ:blɪ,geɪt/ *v.* Must do, Forced to

hunt /hʌnt/ *n.* Search for animals

blackberry /'blæk,beri/ *n.* Dark, sweet berry.

person /'pɜ:rsən/ *n.* Human

corner /'kɔ:rnər/ *v.* Trap with no escape

trail /treɪl/ *n.* Sequence of footprints or signs

print /prɪnt/ *n.* Impression left by pressing.

cling /klɪŋ/ *v.* Hold on tightly

convince /kən'vɪns/ *v.* Make someone believe

somehow /'sʌm,haʊ/ *adv.* Don't know how

disturb /dɪ'stɜ:rb/ *v.* Causing anxiety or distress

Notes

- at large** This means something or someone is "on the loose" or roaming free, and they haven't been caught yet.
- ...reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted...** It simply introduces the specific content of the report. It connects the "report" to what the report actually says.
- feel obligated to do...** This gives the feeling of a strong inner push. It means you feel it is your personal duty or responsibility to do something, even if nobody is strictly forcing you
- ...left behind it a trail of...** means a person, animal, or thing left a line of marks or objects on the ground as they moved forward.

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5 **...clinging to...** To hold onto something very tightly, or to stick to something and refuse to let go.

Summary Writing

Describe how experts concluded the animal was a puma *in 80 words or less*. Do not include anything that is not in the passage.

Answer these questions in note form to get your points:

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 What sort of reports were received by the London Zoo? | 6 Were paw prints and puma fur found too? |
| 2 Were the reports similar to each other? | 7 What was heard at night? |
| 3 Who saw it first? | 8 Was the animal seen in a tree? |
| 4 Did it stay in one place, or did it move around? | 9 Were experts finally sure that the animal really was a puma? |
| 5 What did it leave behind? | |

Vocabulary

Give another word or phrase to replace the following words as they are used in the passage: spotted; accumulate; obligated; claimed; extremely similar; immediately; convinced.

Composition

The woman picking blackberries saw the puma. Expand the following into a paragraph of about 150 words.

Mrs. Stone had spent the whole morning ... It was nearly lunchtime, so she decided... She was just ... when she heard a noise in ... Then she saw an animal which ... She knew it was not a cat because ... The animal suddenly ... and she thought it was going to ... She dropped her basket and ... Hearing the sound, the animal... after which, Mrs. Stone ... and ran all the way home. She told her neighbors that ... but they did not believe her. She also called the police but they... (86 words)

Letter writing

On a full page, show the exact position of each of the following:

The address and date; the beginning of the letter; the Introduction; the Purpose; the Conclusion; the letter-ending; the signature; the P.S. Supply all necessary periods and commas

Key structures

Simple, Compound and Complex Statements (refer to Lesson 73, Volume2)

Exercise

Underline all the connecting words in the passage. Note carefully how simple statements have been joined to make compound or complex statements.

Special difficulties

In the past, people were taught a strict rule that you should never end an English sentence with short words like in, on, at, with,

or from. Today, that old rule is mostly ignored. In everyday English, we end sentences with these short words all the time, especially when we speak

Instead of saying:

About whom are you talking?

That is the film about which I told you

It is better to say:

Who are you talking about?

That is the film I told you about.

Exercises

A Complete these sentences by adding a suitable word to the end of each one:

- 1 What are you looking _____?
- 2 Where is your mother going _____?
- 3 Who has the letter been sent _____?
- 4 This is the house I was born _____.
- 5 What does your decision depend _____?

B Write these sentences again changing the position of the words in italics. Where possible, omit the words *whom* or *which*.

- 1 He is the man about whom we have heard so much.
- 2 The shelf on which you put those books has collapsed.
- 3 From whom did you receive a letter?
- 4 This is the road by which we came.
- 5 Where is the pencil with which you were playing

Multiple choice questions

Choose the correct answers to the following questions.

Comprehension

- 1 Experts eventually decided to investigate _____.
 - (a) because they did not believe that pumas existed in England
 - (b) because they wanted a puma for the London Zoo
 - (c) when a woman saw a puma in a small village
 - (d) because people's descriptions of the puma had a lot in common
- 2 What specific detail persuaded the experts that a puma had been seen in the village?
 - (a) The puma had not attacked the woman.
 - (b) The woman had described the animal she had seen as 'a large cat'.
 - (c) A puma had come very close to a person.
 - (d) The puma had behaved like a cat.

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3 What was the problem the experts were unable to solve?

- (a) How the puma had managed to cover such great distances within a day.
- (b) How the puma had escaped from a zoo.
- (c) Who the puma had belonged to.
- (d) How the puma had climbed a tree.

Structure

4 The accumulating evidence made the experts _____ the animal was a puma.

- (a) to think
- (b) thinking
- (c) think
- (d) thought

5 People said _____ the puma.

- (a) to have seen
- (b) to see
- (c) they saw
- (d) they had seen

6 The animal immediately ran away _____.

- (a) as soon as she saw it
- (b) upon observing her
- (c) having been observed
- (d) when noticing her

7 Pumas never attack a person except _____ cornered.

- (a) they are
- (b) being
- (c) that they are
- (d) when they are

8 The experts were now fully convinced that the animal _____ a puma.

- (a) must be
- (b) should have been
- (c) had to be
- (d) could only have been

Vocabulary

9 The woman saw 'a large cat' _____ five yards away from her.

- (a) at least
- (b) roughly
- (c) no more than
- (d) within

10 A puma will not attack a person unless it feels _____.

- (a) backed into a corner
- (b) in a trap
- (c) at an angle
- (d) under cover

11 A businessman on a fishing trip is probably someone who _____.

- (a) sells fish
- (b) fishes for fun
- (c) nets fish
- (d) catches fish for a living

12 A private collector is someone who collects things) _____.

- (a) for personal enjoyment
- (b) on their own
- (c) in private
- (d) unknown to the public